

93 Uzziah

A strong and gifted king whose pride carried him into the temple and out again a leper.

Uzziah, also called Azariah, became king of Judah at sixteen and reigned fifty-two years, one of the longest reigns in Judah's history. For most of it he did what was right. He sought God, and God made him prosper. He won wars, rebuilt Elath, fortified Jerusalem, dug wells, and loved farming. But success went to his head. He walked into the temple to burn incense, a task God had given only to the priests, and he was struck with leprosy on the spot. He spent his last years shut away while his son ruled for him. The year he died, Isaiah saw the true King on his throne.

At a glance

<i>Names</i>	Uzziah, "the LORD is my strength"; also Azariah (2 Kings 15:1)
<i>Family</i>	Son of Amaziah and Jecoliah; father of Jotham (2 Chronicles 26:1–3)
<i>Reign</i>	52 years from age 16, c. 792–740 BC, with co-regencies
<i>Key places</i>	Jerusalem, Elath, the temple
<i>Key people</i>	Zechariah his adviser; Azariah the priest; Jotham; Isaiah
<i>Main passages</i>	2 Kings 14:21–22; 15:1–7; 2 Chronicles 26
<i>New Testament</i>	Named as "Ozias" in Matthew 1:8–9

"But when he was strong, his heart was lifted up to his destruction: for he transgressed against the LORD his God, and went into the temple of the LORD to burn incense upon the altar of incense."

2 Chronicles 26:16, KJV

The life of Uzziah

Dates are approximate (BC). Many scholars think Uzziah reigned alongside his father Amaziah at first, and that Jotham took over the daily rule after Uzziah became a leper. Scripture does not date the incense incident.

c. 792 BC Age 16	● Made king	The people of Judah make Uzziah king in place of his father Amaziah. <i>2 Kings 14:21; 2 Chronicles 26:1, 3</i>
Early reign	● Rebuilds Elath	He builds Elath on the Red Sea and restores it to Judah. <i>2 Kings 14:22; 2 Chronicles 26:2</i>
In the days of Zechariah	● Seeks God and prospers	He seeks God while Zechariah, a man with "understanding in the visions of God," guides him. As long as he seeks the LORD, God makes him prosper. <i>2 Chronicles 26:4-5</i>
His strong years	● Wars and building	He defeats the Philistines and Arabians, receives gifts from the Ammonites, builds towers, digs wells, and equips a large army with new machines. <i>2 Chronicles 26:6-15</i>
c. 750 BC Probably	● Struck with leprosy	Proud and strong, he enters the temple to burn incense. The priests resist him. As he rages, leprosy breaks out on his forehead. <i>2 Chronicles 26:16-20</i>
c. 750-740 BC Last years	● Lives apart	He lives in a separate house until his death, while his son Jotham rules the palace and judges the people. <i>2 Kings 15:5; 2 Chronicles 26:21</i>
c. 740 BC Age 68	● Dies	He is buried in a field near the royal tombs, "for they said, He is a leper." That year Isaiah sees the Lord on his throne. <i>2 Chronicles 26:22-23; Isaiah 6:1</i>

Key activities

The Zechariah who guided Uziah is not the later prophet Zechariah. Only priests descended from Aaron could burn incense in the holy place (Exodus 30:7-8; Numbers 16:40).

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- 1 **Sought God.** He did right in the LORD's sight and sought God in the days of Zechariah. *2 Chronicles 26:4-5*
 - 2 **Won back territory.** He fought the Philistines, broke down the walls of Gath, Jabneh and Ashdod, and built cities of his own. *2 Chronicles 26:6-8*
 - 3 **Built and farmed.** He built towers in Jerusalem and the desert, dug many wells, and kept herds and vineyards, "for he loved husbandry." *2 Chronicles 26:9-10*
 - 4 **Armed Judah.** He organized a trained army and made machines "invented by cunning men" to shoot arrows and great stones from the towers. *2 Chronicles 26:11-15*
 - 5 **Grew proud.** Once he was strong, his heart was lifted up. *2 Chronicles 26:15-16*
 - 6 **Took the priest's role.** He went into the temple to burn incense. Azariah and eighty priests told him it belonged only to the priests. *2 Chronicles 26:16-18*
 - 7 **Raged and was struck.** He grew angry with the censer in his hand, and leprosy rose on his forehead. He hurried out, for the LORD had struck him. *2 Chronicles 26:19-20*
 - 8 **Ended his days apart.** He lived as a leper, cut off from the house of the LORD, until he died. *2 Chronicles 26:21*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name Uzziah.

Old Testament

2 Kings 14:21–22; 15:1–7	The short account, where he is called Azariah
2 Chronicles 26	The full account, including his pride and leprosy
2 Chronicles 26:22	Isaiah wrote his acts; that record is lost
Isaiah 1:1; 6:1	Isaiah dates his ministry and vision by Uzziah
Amos 1:1; Hosea 1:1; Zechariah 14:5	Other prophets date events by him
Echo: 1 Samuel 13:8–14	Saul offered a sacrifice not his to offer
Echo: Numbers 16:1–40	Korah's men took censers and died

New Testament

Matthew 1:8–9	"Ozias" in the royal line of Jesus
Echo: James 4:6	"God resisteth the proud, but giveth grace unto the humble"
Echo: Hebrews 7:1–3; 8:1	Jesus, King and true high priest

For discussion

1. *Observe:* How long did Uzziah prosper, according to 2 Chronicles 26:5?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think success made Uzziah proud instead of grateful?
3. *Apply:* Uzziah's trouble started when he was strong. Where are you most at risk of pride?
4. *Apply:* Who is a Zechariah for you, helping you seek God? How could you stay close to them?